

PM Case Study: Currently – A Lean News App

1. User Problem

- **Information overload:** News apps bombard users with images, ads, and long articles.
- **Friction:** Logins and subscriptions block casual use.
- **Performance:** Heavy apps drain bandwidth and feel slow.
- **Offline gap:** Users lose access when connectivity drops.

PM Insight: The core unmet need is *fast, frictionless access to trusted headlines*.

2. Product Vision

Deliver a **lightweight, text-first news app** that is:

- **Instant:** Headlines load in milliseconds .
 - **Accessible:** No login or subscription required.
 - **Offline-friendly:** Saved articles available anytime.
 - **Sustainable:** Monetized via ads, not paywalls.
 - **Cost-efficient:** Operates at \$0/month infrastructure cost.
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3. Key Product Decisions

- **Frontend:** React Native + Expo → one codebase for iOS & Android.
- **Offline bookmarks:** AsyncStorage → no accounts, instant access.
- **Backend:** Supabase + Edge Functions → serverless, automated ingestion.
- **Automation:** pg_cron → fetches headlines 3x daily, no manual curation.
- **Monetization:** AdMob → ads injected every 6th item for balance.
- **Design:** Minimalist UI → swipe navigation, clean typography, adaptive icons.

Trade-off: Chose text-only feeds over rich media → faster UX but less visual engagement.

4. KPIs & Success Metrics

- **Engagement:** Daily Active Users (DAU), Saved articles per user.
 - **Retention:** % of users returning within 7 days.
 - **Performance:** Average load time < 1s.
 - **Revenue:** Ad impressions per session, eCPM from AdMob.
 - **Cost:** Infrastructure spend (target = \$0/month).
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5. Risks & Mitigations

- **Content freshness:** Automated cron jobs ensure timely updates.
 - **Security:** Row Level Security prevents unauthorized writes.
 - **Monetization balance:** Ads injected sparingly to avoid churn.
 - **Scalability:** Sandbox environment allows safe testing before production.
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6. Lessons

- **Lean MVP wins:** Focused on headlines only, not full articles.
 - **Automation reduces ops cost:** Cron + Edge Functions eliminated manual work.
 - **Offline-first design builds trust:** AsyncStorage solved a real user pain point.
 - **Sandboxing protects prod:** Safe experimentation is critical for scaling.
 - **Monetization must respect UX:** Ads placed strategically to avoid disruption.
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7. Why People Will Use “Currently”

1. Speed & Simplicity

- Users get headlines instantly without waiting for images, videos, or bloated feeds.
- No login or subscription friction — open the app and start reading.

2. Offline Access

- Saved articles are stored directly on the phone.

- Perfect for commuters, students, or users in regions with unstable internet.

3. Minimalist Design

- Clean, distraction-free UI makes scanning headlines effortless.
- Swipe navigation feels natural and premium compared to cluttered competitors.

4. Trust & Security

- Headlines come directly from trusted sources (Reuters, TechCrunch, etc.).
- Row Level Security ensures data integrity — users know the app isn't harvesting personal info.

5. Free & Sustainable

- No subscription fees.
- Monetization via ads keeps the app free while still generating revenue.

What's the Value Proposition

- **For Users:**
 - A *fast, free, offline-friendly* way to stay updated.
 - No accounts, no paywalls, no clutter.
- **For Developers/Investors:**
 - A *zero-cost backend* that scales automatically.
 - Clear monetization path via AdMob.
 - Sandbox environment reduces risk when iterating.

Differentiation vs. Other News Apps

- **Competitors (Google News, Inshorts, Flipboard):** Heavy, image-rich, require accounts or personalization.
- **Currently:** Text-only, offline-first, zero-cost infrastructure, minimalist UX.

This makes it appealing to:

- **Casual readers** who just want quick headlines.
 - **Emerging markets** where bandwidth and storage are limited.
 - **Privacy-conscious users** who dislike logins and tracking.
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PM Angle: What's Next

- **KPIs to track:** DAU, retention (7-day return rate), saved articles per user, ad impressions.
 - **Growth levers:** Push notifications, category personalization, lightweight sharing features.
 - **Expansion:** Premium tier (ad-free), regional language feeds, partnerships with publishers.
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 In short: **People will use Currently because it solves the pain of bloated, slow, login-heavy news apps by being fast, offline-friendly, and free.**

Try the app: <https://bit.ly/currently>